



TOWED GUN

Need **400 guns**

Conventional 155 mm howitzer towed by military trucks. Has limited mobility to protect itself from enemy fire. (1,580 guns to be built indigenously)

COST: Rs 3,200 crore

STATUS: In limbo after ST Kinetics blacklisted. Fresh RFP expected.



TRACKED

Need **100 guns**

A 155 mm howitzer mounted on a tank chassis. Provides mobile firepower in deserts. Moves swiftly, providing artillery fire for strike formations.

COST: Rs 3,400 crore

STATUS: Government plans to reissue tender.



MOUNTED

Need **814 guns**

A 155 mm howitzer mounted on a six-wheeled truck. Can be rapidly fired without the crew dismounting. Requests for proposals yet to be sent to manufacturers.

COST: Rs 8,500 crore

STATUS: Govt nod. Request for info yet to be sent to manufacturers.

National security is compromised as allegations of paybacks and the ghost of the Bofors gun deal continue to impede the modernisation of the artillery

THE MISSING

| By Sandeep Unnithan |

One of the most iconic visuals of the Kargil war in the summer of 1999 was the sight of Bofors howitzers blasting away at the heights to soften the ground for advancing infantry. It would seem that the artillery gun had vindicated itself and the army would finally restart the modernisation of its field artillery regiments.

A decade later, the army and the artillery are back to what is a shrinking square one. Since the last of the 410 Bofors guns rolled in 1987, the Indian Army has not bought a single new howitzer. It currently has less than 380 of the original Bofors guns and desperately needs at least 400

new howitzers—220 wheeled and 180 tracked—to meet its basic force requirements.

In his autobiography, *In the Line of Fire*, former Pakistan president Pervez Musharraf triumphantly notes that the “bulk of the Indian artillery in Kargil came from strike formations meant for operations in the southern plains”. Meaning, the howitzer-deficient Indian Army had stripped guns off its offensive formations for use in the mountains, thereby losing the ability to enlarge the scope of conflict. This alarming situation continues even today. When Army Chief General Deepak Kapoor reportedly told the Government after the Mumbai attacks last year that the army was not fully prepared for conflict in case punitive strikes escalated into a war with

Pakistan, the depleted artillery regiments was one of the main reasons. “By not augmenting the artillery, the Government is hampering its ability to achieve crucial national objectives,” says Brigadier Gurmeet Kanwal (retired), director of the army’s think tank, Centre for Land Warfare Studies.

The two key percepts of combat power are manoeuvrability and firepower. The present scenario of a nuclear-armed India and Pakistan has ruled out deep manoeuvres by Indian strike formations. Manoeuvres are impossible in the mountains of the north and the North-East in case of a future conflict with China. The answer, say defence analysts, is artillery. Artillery is one of the three key combat arms of any army and complements infantry and battle tanks. An artillery bom-